METHODOLOGY

HOW THE UNIVERSITIES WERE RANKED

With 765 general, 98 medical, 172 technical and 30 law universities to choose from, the India Today Group's annual ranking of Best Universities has a special place in India's academic calendar. It makes critical career decisions easier for aspirants, while offering recruiters, parents, alumni, policymakers, universities and the public an overview of the state of university education.

INDIA TODAY's knowledge partner, Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), followed a rigorous methodology while conducting the survey from March to July 2026. For the objective ranking, MDRA calibrated 120+ attributes grouped under five broad parameters—Reputation & Governance, Academic & Research Excellence, Infrastructure & Living Experience, Personality & Leadership Development and Career Progression & Placement. The ranking used current-year data provided by the universities and also gave parameter-wise scores.

A list of more than 800 qualifying universities, including Institutes of National Importance, was prepared. Postgraduate programmes in four streams—general, medical, technical and law—were evaluated. Only universities offering full-time, in-classroom courses and having produced at least three graduating batches by the end of 2025 qualified.

Experienced experts were consulted to frame the parameters for each category. The indicators and their relative weights were meticulously determined. The weights remained unchanged from past years to ensure consistency and comparability.

Comprehensive objective questionnaires for each category were sent to qualifying universities and uploaded on MDRA's website. Formal invitations, emails, phone calls and follow-ups were used to encourage participation and clarification. Some 192 universities submitted data and supporting documents on time; 190 were ranked.

The submissions and supporting documents were then scrutinised. Data were verified with past records, mandatory disclosures, phone checks, email confirmations and university websites. Institutions were asked to correct or update insufficient or inaccurate information. An objective score was assigned under each parameter, and data normalised to ensure performance was not determined just by aggregate figures.

A perceptual survey covered 305 well-informed respondents—20 chancellors or vice-chancellors, 83 directors, deans or registrars, and 202 senior faculty members, including professors and heads of departments—across cities in four zones.

↘ North: Delhi-NCR, Lucknow, Jaipur and Chandigarh
↘ West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad and Indore
↘ South: Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Coimbatore
↘ East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati and Patna

Respondents provided national and zonal rankings in their fields of experience, assigned 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightage respectively. They also rated universities on a 10-point scale across the five parameters. The objective and perceptual scores were combined in a 50:50 ratio to arrive at the final score.

NUMBER OF PARTICIPATING UNIVERSITIES

TYPE OF UNIVERSITIES	2026	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018
General	132	122	117	110	102	102	91	80	66
Medical	22	20	19	19	16	15	14	14	10
Technical	28	26	28	29	30	29	24	17	10
Law	10	8	9	10	10	10	9	6	5
Total	192	176	173	168	158	156	138	117	91

MOST IMPROVED UNIVERSITIES

Beginning this year, a new category, 'Most Improved Universities', has been introduced to highlight institutions that have made the greatest progress over five years. The ranking measures the percentage improvement in a university's relative position between the 2022 and 2026 rankings.

The MDRA core team was led by CEO Abhishek Agrawal and included senior project director Abnish Jha, research manager Vaibhav Gupta, research executive Robin Singh and assistant managers, EDP, Manveer Singh and Mahesh Joshi. ■